Definition of Communication

- Communication is a process of sharing or transferring or exchanging messages (i.e. information, ideas, feelings) from a source to a receiver (from one person to another) through a medium to achieve a desired response.

Elements of communication

In any communication you are likely to find the following elements (essential parts):

- Source, the message, the channel (medium), the receiver, feedback and noise.

The Source:

- The source is the originator or initiator of the communication process.
- People are involved in the human communication in two roles. They serve as both the sources and the receivers of messages. The source encodes- put an idea or thought into a code.
- The source is also called the **Encoder.**

The Receiver

- This is the target or destination of the message.
- This can be the listener, the reader, in other words, the audience.
- The receiver retranslates or decodes the message into forms that are useful to him/her. **Decoding** is assigning meaning to the idea or thought.
- The receiver is also known as the **Decoder.**
- Decoding is done by the receiver's motor skills and senses i.e. thinking, listening, reading etc.
- The receiver assigns meaning to the message.

The Message

- The message is the content that the source communicates.
- It is the verbal or non-verbal form of the idea, thought, or feeling that one person (the source) wishes to communicate to another person or group of people (the receivers).
- The message includes the symbols (words and phrases), you use to communicate your ideas, as well as your facial expressions, bodily movements, gestures, touch, tone of voice and other nonverbal codes. The message becomes effective if it is interpreted to meet the intent and purpose and not vice-versa.

The Channel

- It is also called the *medium*.
- It is the means (route) by which a message moves from the source to the receiver of any message.
- The message moves from one person to another, by travelling through a channel. Language, signs, symbols, gestures, airwaves, sound waves, twisted copper wires, cables etc, are all communication channels. In person-to-person communication, you send messages through a channel of sound waves and light waves that enable receivers to see and hear you.

Feedback

- **Feedback** is the receiver's verbal and nonverbal response to the source's message.
- It is the receiver's mental or physical response to the speaker's message.
- Feedback tells the source (speaker or writer) whether his/her message was received or not and whether it was correctly received or was misinterpreted.
- It entails the response of the senders-receivers to each other. For instance, you tell me a joke and I smile. The smile to your message is feedback. And when you make a comment about the weather and I make another one we are generating more feedback. Ideally, you respond to another person's messages by providing feedback so that the source knows the message was received as intended.

Noise

- In the communication process, **noise** is any interference in the encoding and decoding processes that reduces the clarity of a message. It is a barrier to the communication process.
- There are two kinds of noise; **physical noise** and **psychological noise.**
- Physical noise keeps the message from being heard. An example might be that your learning is interrupted by some students talking loudly, by sound of cars passing by, or the helicopter passing overhead etc. Physical noise could also come from distracting sights like dancing outside your classroom or from an unusual behaviour like someone standing too close for comfort.

Psychological noise

- **Psychological noise** on the other hand, occurs in the minds of the senders-receivers. This kind of noise usually occurs when the senders-receivers are distracted by something. For example, during lectures, a learner does not hear the lecture because he is thinking about lunch; failure to understand because they are day dreaming about loved ones; if it is an adult learner may be they are thinking about bills. Whatever kind of noise, the bottom line is that noise interferes with receiving, interpreting or providing feedback about a message.

- Other barriers to the communication process could be language- the case of the sender using jargons or difficult vocabulary, mental problems such as worries between the source and the receiver, the use of bad remarks by the lecturer etc.
- This creates incomplete communication which results in bad feedback e.g. boredom, frustration, poor performance etc.
- It has to be noted that communication is a two way process and both the sender and receiver affect each other.

Characteristics of Human Communication

- Whenever communication takes place, there is a speaker and a listener (or a writer and reader) who must interact.
- The speaker has a *purpose* for speaking while the listener is interested in discovering the purpose. The listener may ask; what does this tell us?
- Giving each other turns. This is usually common in face-to-face interactions. At least two people who influence each other's actions to some extent are involved. In other words, communication involves both the source and the receiver

- It is possible for communication to have both intentional and unintentional results or effects. For instance, at times, a joke may be interpreted as an insult; a friendly gesture as a proposal or sexual harassment. On this, you have to know that what we say or do may not always be interpreted in the way we intended. The receiver may understand it in a totally different way than we thought or planned. This is unintentional result of communication.

- Communication involves the use of symbols such as movement, gestures and so on, which actually represent the thoughts and feelings of the speaker. To some extent, both the sender and the receiver understand the meanings of these symbols.

NOTE: *Communication need not be successful for us to say that it has really taken place. So long as a message is sent and the other person receives the message we say some communication has taken place.*

Diagramatic illustration of the communication process

Types of Communication

Depending on the medium used for communication, there are many different types of communication but they are classified into two basic types of communication

These two types of communication are Verbal and Non-Verbal Communication.

Verbal Communication

This is communication which uses words, i.e. language. Verbal communication can either be **Oral** (using voice) or **written.**

Oral Communication

- Communication that uses words from the mouth through language.
- This is the type of communication used in face-to-face interactions, on the phone, radio, TV, at meetings, assemblies or public rallies. **(Go to Situtns b4 advanta)**

Advantages

- **Feedback is immediate:** When using oral communication, you can deal with any signs of misunderstanding on the spot. In addition, you can make corrections, amplifications or explanations on the spot.

Situations of Oral Communication

- When it is important for discussions to easily get immediate feedback through nonverbal messages .
- When emotions are high. Oral communication provides more opportunity for both to let off steam, cool down.
- When the receiver is too busy or preoccupied to read the message. Oral communication provides more opportunity to get attention and interest from the receiver.
- When the sender wants to persuade or convince. Oral communication provides more flexibility, opportunity for emphasis, to remove resistance .
- When criticism of the receiver is involved. Oral communication provides more opportunity to accomplish this since it is less threatening than the formalized writing.

Advantages continue

- It provides a ready setting which contributes to the way the message is interpreted and understood.
-) **Setting contributes to the way the message will be understood:** Oral messages have an aura of the informal. For instance, in an organisation, an oral reprimand of a colleague or junior may be taken more lightly or more favourably than a written one. In addition, the setting (place) in which such interaction takes place is part of the message for instance in a bar, at a party, in an office etc.

- **Paralanguage** helps in making the message clearer i.e. gestures, body movements, tone of voice and other paralinguistic features such as pitch, tempo, loudness (volume) etc.
- **Problem solving:** Oral communication is ideal for establishing relationships and for solving problems or resolving conflicts.

Disadvantages of Oral Communication

- Oral communication is transitory in nature: There is no permanent record that one can refer to at a future date.
- Effectiveness of oral communication heavily depends on the mood of the listener at that particular time. (Impatience, prejudice, anxiety)

Written Communication

- This is the type of communication that uses written materials. Notes, memos, letters, reports, notices, minutes, circulars, general announcements, newsletters and leaflets are some of the common ways of the written communication used in organizations.
- It is the ability to express oneself effectively by means of written symbols (either printed or handwritten).
- Good written communication is essential for business purposes (it is recognized as being a vital business skill

- Written communication is used not only in business but also for informal communication purposes. Mobile SMS, letters, etc, are some of the examples.
- The written communication can be edited and amended many times before it is communicated to the second party to whom the communication is intended. This is one of the main advantages of using writing as the major means of communication in business activity.
- Writing is like any other skill in that it can be developed with practice and appropriate training.

Advantages of Written Communication

- Provides a permanent record; Ideas expressed in writing achieve the permanency that fixes responsibility. This makes it possible to verify very essential information such as dates, times, figures, names etc. It is because of this that people insist on having written information to confirm oral conversation or messages for authenticity, authority and validity.
- Written communication can reach distant places, far and wide where people may not be on the phone.

- Written communication can be read at the convenience of the recipient. It enables people to read when they are in a more receptive mood or if they are in a different frame of mind they can shelve and read it some other time. If the message is not understood, the message can be read over and over again e.g. written exam over oral exam.
- People tend to remember better what they see in print.

- Written messages are often better structured by their composers. Words and phrases are more carefully chosen than they are in oral communication. Thus, the process of writing forces the composer to think clearly and to present his/her ideas logically. S/he has time to edit and proof- read his/her work.
- Written communication is best for those serious matters which we want to keep a record of e.g. policies, procedures, timetables, technical and statistical information.

Disadvantages of written communication

- We cannot be certain that the message will receive the attention we think it deserves. Executives often have masses of letters, memos etc that vie for their attention therefore there is no guarantee that our messages have been attended to as we may want them to.
- Feedback is slow. Therefore not good for solving problems.
- There are no nonverbal aids to help the reader get the meaning. The message may not be understood as intended.

- Language errors (e.g. bad grammar, poor construction, spellings and punctuation) may make the message vague or altogether make communication impossible.
- There is risk of confidential messages falling into the wrong hands or being received at the wrong time.

Non-Verbal Communication

- Nonverbal communication is the process of communicating through sending and receiving wordless messages . No language is used.
- Such messages can be communicated through gesture, body language or posture; facial expression and eye contact
- It can also be communicated through object communication such as clothing, hairstyles, voice quality.
- People should pay much attention on nonverbal communication because people usually remember more of what they see than what they hear (seeing is believing).
- Body language fails to hide the truth even if there are attempts to do so (lips, the voice tone, gesture, etc).
- Therefore, non verbal communication help people in recognizing the truth – people tend to believe the body language first before the spoken words.

1. Body language

- It is the way people use their bodies to send messages
- Positive body language include: relaxed posture, arms relaxed, good eye contact, nod agreement, smile at humour, leaning forward, etc
- Negative body language include: body tension, arms folded, speaking hand-to-mouth, fidgeting, yawning, etc

❑ **Posture:**

- It can be used to determine a participant's degree of attention or involvement, the difference in status between communicators, and the level of fondness a person has for the other communicator
- Posture is understood through such indicators as direction of lean, body orientation, arm position and body openness. Leaning backward, or lying on the desk, for example, can communicate laziness, tiredness and boredom.

Body language Continued…

- **Gesture:**
- It is a non vocal bodily movement intended to express meaning
- They can be articulated with the hands, arms, or body and also the movement of the head, face, eyes, eg. the winking and rolling of one's eye, nodding, etc
- **Haptics:**
- It is the touching as communication. These include handshake, holding hands, kissing (cheek, lip, hand) back slapping, a pat on the shoulder, etc
- What meanings do we assign on how, why and where someone touches us
- Touching of oneself can also communicate greatly, for instance, licking, picking, holding and scratching

Eye Contact and gazing

- The way you look at someone can communicate many things - it is also important in maintaining the flow of conversation.
- Eyes are the best indicators of emotions. Eye contact can also indicate interest, involvement, attention and openness. It can also elicit a feeling of trust.
- Downward glance is generally associated with modesty or dishonesty depending on the situation.
- When people fail to look others in the eyes, it can seem as if they are invading or trying to hide something. On the other hand, too much eye contact can seem confronting or intimidating.

- In some cultures, it is considered extremely important to look into the eyes of the person we are talking to. If we do not, we are at risk of being considered dishonest or having something to hide. Listeners may also feel that we are not interested in them if our eyes are not focussed on them.
- Eye contact is also an important way of gauging audience reaction to your speech. If you are presenting something interesting, the eyes will tell it all and if they are confused by what you are saying, the eyes will equally spell it out.

2. Sound language (Acoustics)

- These acoustics are also known as **paralanguage** (vocalics) and it is a study of non verbal cues of voice
- Various acoustic properties of speech such as tone, pitch, accent and rate of speaking can give off non verbal cues. They convey emotions that can accurately be judged regardless of the content of the message
- As a communicator, be sensitive to the influence of these paralanguages
- The pitch, tone of a person's voice, have something to say over and above the words themselves
- Depending on the tone, the simple word 'oh!' can mean many things: surprise, mistake, pain, happiness, boredom, understanding, misunderstanding, wonder, etc
- The rate of speech also tells us something about the speaker's feeling. People talk fast when they are excited /anxious, for example, and they are slow when depressed

3. Time language (Chronemics)

- Time or chronemics can be used differently with respect to individuals and even cultures
- Time perceptions include punctuality, willingness to wait, interactions , the speed of the speech and how long people are willing to listen
- The way time is used can provide information about people as individuals
- Silence can also communicate depending on the situation and it can either be positive or negative in the communication process – it can create tension, and uneasiness or create a peaceful situation
- There are two types of time systems: **monochronic,** where things are done one at a time and time is scheduled, arranged and managed; **polychronic,** where several things can be done at once, and a more fluid approach is followed.
- Monochronic cultures include America and Canada; Polychronic cultures include Latin and Africa.

4. Space language (Proxemics)

- This is how people use and perceive the physical space around them. The space between the sender and the receiver of the message influences the way the message is interpreted
- The perception varies across cultures, and according to Americans, the space can be divided into four categories

i) **Intimate:** This distance is primarily for confidential exchanges and is almost always reserved for close friends and the distance is usually below 45cm

ii) **Personal:** This distance is comfortable for conversation between friends, usually from 46cm to about 1.2m

iii) **Social:** This is the ordinary distance people maintain from one another for most social and business exchanges, usually from 1.2m to 3.5m

iv) **Public:** At this distance, perhaps in a shopping mall or street, people barely acknowledge each other's presence. At most, they give a nod or a shake of the head, over 3.5m

Space language (Proxemics)

- How close do you stand to the one with whom you are communicating; this will affect the level of comfort, of those receiving your message

❖ **Dressing and grooming**

➢ Dressing is also another way of transmitting messages. The way one dresses tells a story. It is important to dress to suit the occasion. Clothes and decorations on the body, like body language, send messages about ourselves to all we meet. At times, we dress to indicate the kind of person we wish to play in life.

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- These are often used to communicate information about oneself. Things involved are objects, often clothes, jewelries, trinkets which expresses one's interests, hobbies, status or life style.
- This also concerns issues of grooming
- The uniform, badges, for example, also give information about job, status, religion, tradition, authority etc

Pictures

- Pictures are very helpful in communication. They are attractive to the eye, they also communicate in an instant and comprehensive manner to the illiterate. For example, if you went to a foreign land whose language you do not understand it would be easier for you to trace a toilet basically by looking at the pictures of man and woman on the door posts.

Advantages of pictorial communication

Pictorial communication is paramount in that pictures are:

- international
- instantaneous in their impact
- comprehensible to the illiterate
- easily remembered

Disadvanatages

- Much as there are a number of advantages with pictures, you must be aware that they have some disadvantages. They cannot be used for such materials as:

- Reasoned arguments
- Detailed instructions
- Exact information
- Definition
- Records of discussions Legal matters etc

Why Nonverbal Communication

- Non verbal codes are used to establish and maintain interpersonal relationship
- It expresses emotions, interpersonal attitudes, and one's personality
- Non verbal communication can be used to repeat, accent, and (or) complement the verbal messages
- It helps in understanding people's inner motives / feelings and their personalities

- By becoming aware of conscious or unconscious non verbal signals, you can more accurately decode the message that other people send you